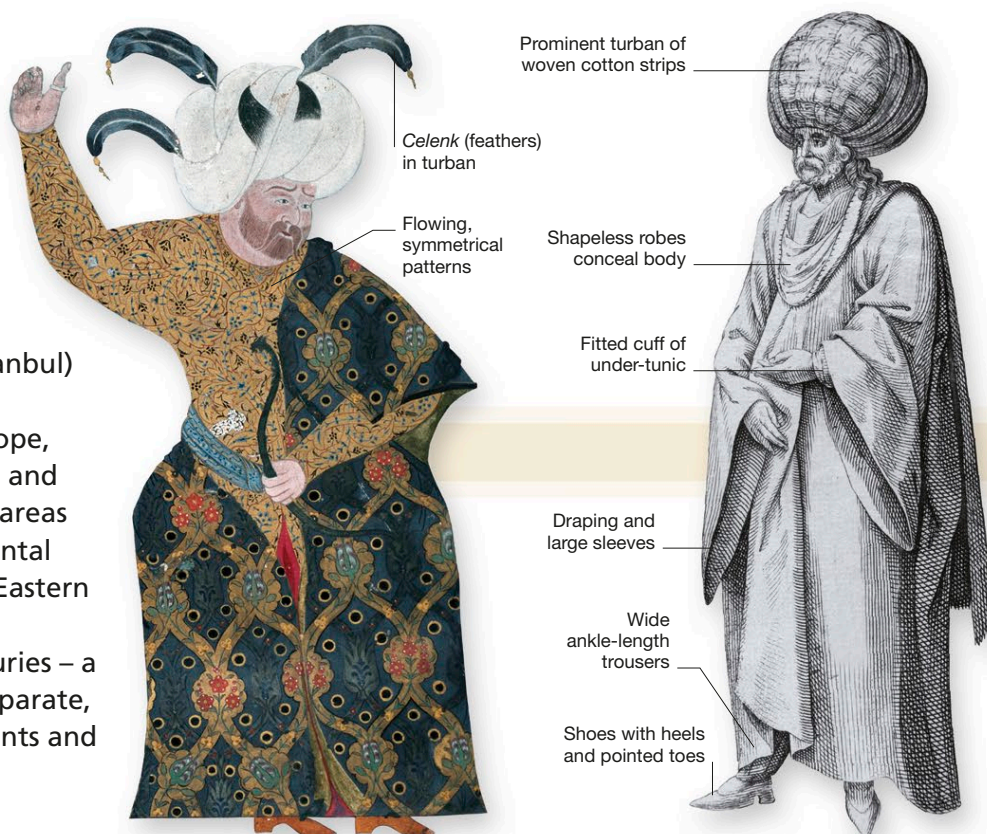


1450–1624

OTTOMAN FINERY

The Ottomans conquered Constantinople (now Istanbul) in 1453 and made it the centre of a vast empire.

Their territory covered most of south-eastern Europe, stretching to the edges of Austria and Poland-Lithuania, and included Hungary and the Balkans. Clothing in all these areas showed a strong oriental influence in long robes, horizontal fastenings, and turbans. Venetian fashion also drew on Eastern ideas through trade with Byzantium. Muslim Ottomans continued to wear the flowing garments of earlier centuries – a contrast with the growing Western passion for fitted, separate, rigid clothing. Ottoman dress used fewer, simpler garments and depended more on nuances of fine-quality textiles and embroidery than novelties of fashion. The most obviously foreign difference was that women in Eastern areas often wore trousers, while in the West, European split-leg garments were exclusively male.



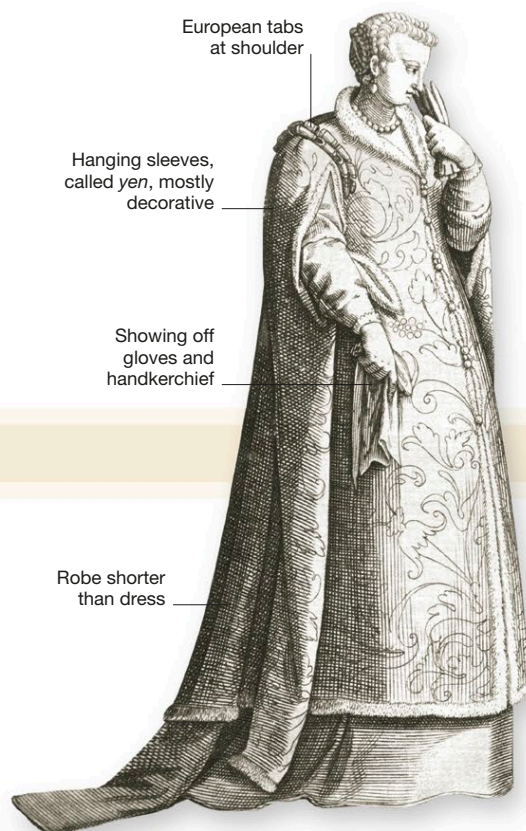
Intricate silks A miniature of Selim II shows off the lavish colours and sinuous patterns of his clothing. Caftans' large surfaces were ideal for showcasing quality textiles, which expressed prestige and power rather than fashionable cut.

Turbans and loose tunics Turbans were the most significant point of difference between Western and Eastern dress. This Armenian nobleman's draped clothing is in sharp contrast to contemporary tailored fashion.

TEXTILES



Constantinople had long been a trading centre for textiles to Europe. Likewise, Ottoman merchants imported costly silk velvets from Genoa, Venice, and France. Local textile weaving used the stylized, two-dimensional motifs of Islamic art in harmonious repetition and striking colour combinations. Venetian Gentile Bellini's painting of a Turkish scribe, made when he visited the Ottoman court around 1480, shows a pomegranate motif and richly contrasting fabrics.



Long robe with hanging sleeves This courtesan from Padua wears a fur-lined brocade robe with central button closure. Elements of Eastern or caftan styles had become usual in European clothing by the late 16th century.



Royal caftan This late 15th-century silk and gold damask caftan belonged to Sultan Beyazid II. Caftans were the main garment worn by Ottoman men and women and eastwards into Persia (now Iran) and Central Asia. Cut, length, and width varied.